

A9: (Un)intended Consequences

LIS 470 – Individual Assignment

Assignment Description

Designs have consequences. In this assignment you will identify negative consequences (both intended and unintended) of digital designs.

Dark Pattern

Dark patterns are techniques that apps and websites use to get users to do something they may not have intended to, such as purchasing a product or signing up for a mailing list. Look for examples of dark patterns in your everyday life and then take an image of and write about one of them. In your writeup, include an image of the dark pattern and discuss what the user intended to do, what they did (or might have done) that they did not intend, and how the interface made the unintended action more likely. Also describe how the interface might be redesigned to make the unintended action clearer, or less likely to happen unintentionally.

Unintended Consequences

Even the best laid plans can have unintended consequences. For example, introducing eucalyptus trees to the United States as a cash-crop led to more wildfires and the destruction of other agricultural products. Digitizing medical records made it easier to copy-paste between records, leading to data errors. Identify one unintended consequence of a digital design and discuss its impact on individuals or society. Describe what the design was trying to do, what happened instead, how the design supported this outcome, and what might be done to make the unintended consequence less likely.

What to Hand In

Turn in a **PDF document** (not a Word document) with the following:

1. Your description of a *dark pattern*
2. Your description of an *unintended consequence*

Due Date

See Canvas

Grading Rubric

This assignment is worth a total of 5 points. You will earn a half-point for each of the following:

1. Submission includes your name and the date
2. Dark Pattern: Includes image of the dark pattern
3. Dark Pattern: Includes what the user was intending to do
4. Dark Pattern: Includes what the user ended up doing that was not intended
5. Dark Pattern: Describes how the interfaces makes the unintended action more likely
6. Dark Pattern: Describes how the interface might be redesigned
7. Unintended Consequence: Describes what the design intended to do
8. Unintended Consequence: Describes the unintended outcome
9. Unintended Consequence: Describes how the design supported this outcome
10. Unintended Consequence: Describes the design might be redesigned to make the unintended outcome less likely